

PaleoRik

A sequence of poems
originating from early works
by **Rik Roots**

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Dedicated to

Angela K, David B, David G, Helen N, Helene A,
James B, James H, John S, Laurie S, Louise R,
Mark R, Martin S, Mick D, Paul G, Piers G,
Ron T, Ronald F, Tim K, Val L,
Vicci B, Vincent de S ... and all those
who endured the first drafts of these poems
during those long, long winter evenings
in Stukeley Street. Thank you all!

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London

Should he ever speak of home,
it would be of the land he would tell:
villages on sea level plains would again build
in the midst of his eye.

He would trek in sentences, friends he has known –
paths trod as a child in hand-me-down shoes.
The music. The radios. The open grate fire.
The gossip of neighbours
who visited for news.

Of home he will not speak: not to me.
He will drink the juice of his home
in this mock ale house. He will smoke.
He will listen to records, captured rhythm,
smile, talk of work and weather
to spartan associates: he will not gossip.
The gossip bears no depth for him.
We are alien twins glance-met in London,
and the mirror before me
is smudged.

Rituals

Autumn would bring us rituals to school.

Conkers: bootlace strung,
hung from coat toggles on proud display.
Until smashed.

All Hallow's eve and tall-cone witch hats:
card masks green finger painted – soon torn,
berry potions, and dare-stolen grave chippings
slipped quietly to the pockets of rivals and foes
as a curse.

Fireworks for the fifth:
celebrate the demise of our grand manikin
paraded on shoulders around the school ground,
lighting the close night with its broken-wood pyre
and sprouting buttered jacket potatoes
from the embers.

Poppies:
Card-petalled, stem-chewed, Haig-stamped,
that led us coldly as mist to morning
to the sword-carved cross ahead of the church
where once the lintel gallows stood
and we were paraded, dreaming
of warming cold rain from woolen uniforms

– it was beyond me: only a poppy,
and I knew dead soldiers breathe again
when playtime has gone.

Cremations

The sun has swilled caskets of Spanish wine
and reeled from its path – falling too far north.

This summer bleaches me.

The heat has stripped me naked and now
I am laid out on a bed in a windowless room,
burning, sweat dribbling past chest pubes
to puddle my navel: I cannot sleep.

In my shorts I had walked from Leyton station
past the Birbeck Arms on North Birbeck Road
to the breath-stench tunnels of the Cathall Estate.
In three weeks of heat the community lawns
have painted their blades brown and followed the worms
to deeper earths: feral rottweilers were tracking me,
padding cautiously on my shadow,
licking water from my blistered thighs.

Taking the oven-lift to an estate-tower roof,
I found Leytonstone catholic graveyard
laid out below: squared rows of granite crosses
and marbled angels watching Birbeck fry.
Two holes had been dug: black doors to heaven –
no caskets filled them yet.
The bereaved will wait until the bedding of the sun
before laying to rest their memory-corpses:
the departed reek less in the dusk.

Kingfisher Pool

Once I found a waterfall.

I watched the kingfisher perched on his rock.

With a blue flume he dove deep to the abyss
and surfaced with gaping bream in his beak.

I started – and stalled.

A fear of water caressing the face
held me as a stringed mannequin
– shrinking the bollocks as again
the kingfisher wet his oval head.

Perched on his rock after,
one feathered eye spoke:
scared of the waters?

Maybe a muscle rippled, as slowly
a shirt was un-burdoned and dropped.
A quick circle of glancing stare
was touched on the barricade trees
as button-holes puckered their mouths wide,
and the denims fell – expertly crumpled.

Dive! The beak chattered. *Dive to touch the stones
where the glass Sargasso elvers grow,
eating worms.*

And I dared. As a pink walrus
tattooed here and there with hair on hide,
I plunged within the waterfall pool:
and mouthed a scream for shock
as my bubbles were lifted to the pond-skater home.

Cold! The airspheres bellowed. *Free!*

James

James watches the monkey organ-chained.

It huddles askance and will not look:

the whites of its eyes avoid the crowds,
and the crowds claim James and the monkey
is gone –

and James is funneled through canvas tunnels.

Crowds scramble to counters of baubles and jewels
where hawkers and dealers line the sides
screaming their wares, beckoning James
to finger the goods, catching his ears
with prices and bargains James cannot afford,
then to throw him away, garbage,
thrusting his presence from their trestles,
their caustic rebukes stinging his sockets, flaming
his eyes –

and James is lost:

he lowers his head down to
his shoulders and sits in a
mire of legs and boots and dirt and
heels, eyewhites straining away and
ears handshacked, with a
shivering chin tapping
patellas and whispering in
silence: *go away* –

go away –

Uri

Uri slides motionless across the curve of the skies,
eyeless, checking niches and ledges
within balustrades of uncapped lintel
steeping from plains of choking sands,
aching to reach his fingers.

He descends.

Trailing rainbows, he swathes
through shoals of angels and butterflies
and floats in the maw of a cavern cathedral
besieged by urchins driven
from deserts beyond to graze
the swaying alters of his Eden.

Taking a spear of latexed steel
Uri impales the aliens, cracking shells:
rending flesh to the salt-current whim
until the last urchin spine drifts across
the coral floor and his starving lungs burn.
Uri clammers liquid ladders back to the skies
– leaving parrots and angels to feed on detritus
with butterflies and morays and dog sharks
and crabs.

Breaking the wave-dome, Uri pushes his mask
to the top of his head and gasps air through teeth,
tastes the salt in the breeze.

Choice no Choice

Into the left eye shimmers a desert
complete horizons - granuled aridity
clean sterile pure

Into the right orb shiver contingencies
cold cramp space duty food
emotion inanition inertia
order rupture leisure sex shit
heart death beer sweat
sweat heat sex death

```
On a grey morning      On a cold morning
      <- On this morning ->
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it could be simple to pluck the
right eye
from this head, let the blood
stumble
from this socket, allow scabs to
drag
over this cheek, bring a desert
back home

Search

I only search for him at the weekend:
week is a time for duty, support –
tasks more important than me.
My quarry, the fox, hides his shadow in faces,
a slick flick of an eyeball down,
a stare edged across overlong
disrupting the camouflage, on trains,
across streets, quick to move on.
If my veins did not flicker, I would not know:
perhaps he was here.

I traipse in search of different scenes.
Here is a bar where men converse,
words smoothing cross-grain desires.
A den the dogs have learnt to fear.
Brush safe, a form stretches in the aisles,
curls under stools, observes by tables.
Now I can see him, a proud beast,
clear at the edge on my eye.
I have his scent. He has mine.
Teeth smile.

Flaw

Flaw sits in my cupboards
Flaw stands behind doors
Flaw hides in the curtains
 whittling its claws.
Flaw smirks in my mirrors
Flaw shadows my back
Flaw skips in my nightmares -
 it has that knack.

Flaw crumples my clothing
Flaw stains my best sheets
Flaw spits when I'm hungry
 and still I eat.
Flaw plagues my horizons
Flaw makes you all see
that Flaw is my partner
 a true part of me.

East of Islington

1. Cannonbury

Half-six of an evening and already
the paving has been crisped smooth,
no stone, no ledge has been spared
its Dickens-winter decoration.

Shuffling unbalanced left and right
I chuff my way home, trailing
exhalations behind me.

2. Essex Road

Some shops remain open, huddled
within their festive gear. Like candles
and moths they beggar my reflexes –
Enter, they carol-chant my cash. Spend.
Brittle, I walk on, fearful of falling
if I should take a wrong step
away from the track to my door.

3. Northchurch

The cars in Northchurch Road
squat by their kerbs, henges in shadows.
Jack-the-Lad has beaten me here, riming
each car window with a glittery glaze.
Stopping, I try to sign
a frosted screen, but my hands
are un-gloved: my fingers stick.

Hunters

From the desert brush a dappled cat
sleeks in through an open window,
noses the furniture: sits,
regards me with eyes of jasper.
Offering a back-hand for perusal,
it is accepted, rasped for salt,
marked and ignored. We gaze at shadows

thrown from the torchlights close in the night.
Forms beyond call unseen, mouths in hand-cups:
identify and greet, carouse and touch.
I dress in cotton, abandon the room
and walk sand paths, hunting flesh.

Gridded within rows and columns
of paint peeled collonnades,
prey can be found. I watch
moon-moths cascade in pheromones
over pillars supporting the wheeling star-plate:
when desert winds gust, some fail in the dance
and pillow towards my temple trap.

I chase, leaping to claw great ghosts from the air,
fisting at wings. Palming a fat, flying grub
into the stocks of a decayed history.
Claiming the prize I breed fire,
strip wings and unhinge legs,
skewer the body on a copper rod.
Sing. Heat. Eat.

Scared

When the angels came to take the world
across the universe to heaven,
I heard a familiar trumpet blown
– softly, not quite off-key –
as I crouched in my quilted bed alone.

When the dancers of death recalled the winds
out from the bellows that blew them,
I smelt remnants, the faintest taint
of cheap cologne at the top of the stairs,
and shook.

When the sons and daughters of Flamer Jack
crowded the porch to proclaim the departure
of one I had tried not to love,
my eyes burned reflections of their swaying flames
– and I cried.

It was not a father's pulse that failed:
rather a slice of my Breath. Yet sometimes –
when the precious clock strikes, when winter comes,
when I sense cheap cologne by my side –
I know he is there,

and I learn once more my muscled Breath
and my Breath that is stopped
must stay sundered a while longer yet.
The lesson hurts me: it burns me.
And still I am scared of the wound.

Democracy

I smile to the video in the shop window.
Someone smiles at me from the stage of the TV.
When I wave, I wave back.

I walk from work, along Victoria Street
to Parliament Square. Cameras
line the iron gates: I do not smile.
This is not my stage.

In the shadows of towers a polite man
talks to electronics. When he smiles,
I see headlined guile. The face is sincere:
the eyes laugh.

Above, talking wires whisper
farewell to pre-neon light.
A great bell stirs in its analogue tower:
shivers a boom through cables and space –
I smile to a man behind a camera,
step away from his frame,
become free.

Paradise

An exile in paradise
weeps, hearing life,
life gone, boys with
machetes. Sliced pigs,
bullets and birdsong.

Paradise seems unnoticed by a second, whose eyes
(he says) boiled when his shack was torched.
He remembers to smile when a camera is clicked.

This one, pretty in a dress,
sings songs and claps hands,
shows the strangers her pictures –
fat mummies and stick daddies
with slits crayon-stitched and
bandaged with magic. Mummy will come
to paradise soon, she says.

A fourth, older, wiser,
twelve, heats water
for drinking, shrinks
when the wood cracks.

A soldier with no boots watches the boys
play football through the camp. He wants
to play too, but the footballers are older,
and don't know he exists.

The sixth eats.

Paradise smells better
when the hunger
has gone.

Fallen

Here lies a church: its bricks, dis-mortared,
lump across the wild-grass park. A cross
topples into hawthorn thickets. Weathered graves
erupt crazed from once secret gardens.
One wall still stands, a messenger-board for old loves,
trite advice; affiliations.

Here stands the mould of a boy, whose fingers drip
from small hands hugging a candle snuffed in the rain.
Cotton has been hung across the loins; a tide of soot
twines over the hair. The eyes have bleached; hoar-frosts
weave across the face. The feet are marked by passing dogs,
as is the pedestal, crusted in bottles and butts.

Cold clouds shade the walls of the place where once I played.
Iron gates are rusted shut: gravel paths have grassed over
and thistles taint the playing greens. There are no rules
to keep now; no signposts; no borders. Just crumbling statues
to remember the past and the bricks of a universe
that fell long ago.

City

One Tuesday, I tasted a different city:
walked along Hackney's canal at the close
of the day, sat chatting with a friend
in a canal-side pub. Noticed the green
between the grey; touched air in place of grime.
Forgot that this was my home.

I can see the dome of St Paul's from the office window.
At dusk, stray sunbursts gild its white walls
and again the magic happens, transporting me
to a city I rarely see. Though the moment passes
and spatters of rain stipple the window,
I remember the passing pride.

Discovery

Dedicated to Nigel

This is a strange territory: I met it last
when I was small, hand-led in family formation.
Now that I stand tall, the terrain aches its hues.
Horizons are more subtle, the landscapes more distinct.
Deserts mingle with forests; streams flood fields.
Complexities encourage an expedition
I abandoned long ago.

Since you marked my map, I feel surer of my step.
I can avoid the pedestals others have built, track
faint trails through gardens; accept flowers for their colour,
fruit for their taste. Mazes I once hid from, confused, scare me
no more. There is nothing simple in this emotion, nothing pure,
except the map with its crosses, your touch
and my trust.

Relativity

(Dedicated to Iain)

Today I am left in bed, my head tethered to a pillow by stout phlegm cords.

When my friend came back from Paris
he had but two platelets left
to his name. He christened them in memory
of friends: Cabernet and Sauvignon.

Lungs hold their breath, stunned by this vile ague's performance.

After resisting the pleas of surgeons to scrape
the remains of his spleen from his guts he flew
home to Sydney, rehearsing his Strine slang
on the way to Heathrow.

I hack my appreciation as another cycle of shivers spins to its climax.

He left us, the proud father of thirty
one brand new baby blood cells,
each one precious,
all home grown.

Eclipse

For some you are pretty to look at; to others
a quirk of nature, a passage of time.
I know I am smaller than you, and you
are my teacher.

From the moment the rip-tide tore
the waters from my cot and life's
breath stung my lungs, you have
taught me.

Through your filter I have touched
the world, seen through its shadows,
its secrets. Your revolution fixed my path,
set my actions before me.

You sicken me. I dodged your shadow
as it judged the land, watched it fall
a hundred miles south (though at the last
my shadow deserted me).

And I felt the breath of your lesson
rush a curving swathe across the sea,
the land, past Paris and Turkey to the oceans
beyond India.

Murderous bitch! Kings should have died,
not the streets of shoddy Golcuk. Money loving misers
should have knelt helpless before you, not
the towers of Istanbul.

Once more to me you teach an end.
I cling to the frame of the door you rip
from my grasp, deny my eyes the sight
of mortality,

relieved that my soil stays solid, that
Hackney stands still, and I in it,
and in a week your face will shine full.
And I will adore you again.

Dinosaur

I have a dinosaur perched in my palm.
It should be free, but the arm
is bloodied. I look within the fixed eye
as I swab the parallel gouges
clean.

Cat curses pounce across my back.
When I look back he ignores me,
disdain shivering the stout brush tail.
Ear flicks inform me I shall pay
for thieving his toy.

The wound clots. Alien muscles slip
within the rainbow skin, restless.
As I un-cup my hands a sharp, ritual peck stabs
my thumb. It runs, forelimbs sprint-pumping
as it gaits away.

Resurrection

I see a bone of still-furled crocus, brave
against the tufts of winter wearied grass -
a lawn of shroud across Augustine's graves.
It juts too soon, for sure, for Candlemass

has barely gone. But this is Hackney: here
the folks appreciate defiant shows
of cocksure grit. A single flower dares
to loft its petals, kiss the frost and grow

beyond the long-dead skeletons so I
must best that challenge. I must cast away
the soft embrace of winter's mortal sigh,
its weave of tomb-deep ice that disarrays

my joy of heat and hope and you and pain:
wear my summer shorts today in cold rain.

Decorating

I start with the lights. Good friends I've loved,
they start with the tree – sought and bought with bristles
and cones, balanced on a stand in the front room. Heirloom
baubles then mixed with glitter and gauzes, chocolates
and candlelights, each layer added as a conversation,
their story wrapping christmas fresh for the year. No,

I start with the lights, check each bulb in its socket
before I wind them round my plastic spruce, settle the plug,
switch the show on. I pause with each snowy card received:
a smile for the decoded signature; changed addresses noted
in my dieting address book, shedding its leaves. Then I tack
holly and mistletoe to my front door, a dozen
sticky berries to greet the unknown year.